CORE 2500-22 · VANDERBILT · FALL 2026

Sport, Culture & Society Field Guide

Everything the first four weeks of readings actually argue — plus the map of where the rest of the semester goes, and the two habits that decide your grade.

Prof. Gabriel A. Torres Colón **Meets** TR 1:15–2:30, Garland
Graded on 8 quizzes · 14 reflections · attendance

01 How to actually pass this class

The grade is not built out of exams. It is built out of small, repeated, easy-to-forget tasks. That is good news — if you never miss one.

PIECE	COUNT	WORTH	WHAT IT REALLY TESTS
Quizzes	8	10 pts	Main *argument* of the readings due that day + the lecture slides from the class before
Reflections	13	10 pts	Self-assessed with a rubric. No AI allowed. Honest effort.
Final reflection	1	20 pts	“Ultrarealism and Human Flourishment”
Media / current events	–	–	Assigned by email + Brightspace, **not on the syllabus**

THE THREE WAYS PEOPLE LOSE THIS GRADE

1. Attendance. After two unexcused absences you lose **10% of your final grade for every additional class.** That is the single biggest risk in the course — bigger than any quiz.
2. Deadlines. Everything is due **before class begins**. A missed quiz is a 0, no make-up. Late reflections drop a letter grade per day.
3. Not checking email. Media assignments are required but appear nowhere on the syllabus.

Two upsides worth knowing: quiz points you lose **can be made up with extra-credit assignments** later in the semester, and reflections are self-graded — so the cost of a bad week is recoverable. Blatantly gaming the self-assessment is treated as cheating.

The 25-minute quiz-prep routine

1. **Write the one-sentence thesis** of each reading due. If you can't, you're not ready. (Examples for the first four weeks are the “Argument in one line” boxes below.)

2. **Name the evidence.** Quizzes are objective questions — they reward remembering the study, the place, the number, the person.
3. **Re-read the slides from the previous class,** one concept per slide. The syllabus says this explicitly.
4. **Say the counter-argument out loud.** Nearly every reading in this course is arguing *against* a popular story (Man the Hunter, the 10,000-hours rule, race as biology).

02 The semester in one picture

The course moves outward: from bodies and evolution → to social difference and power → to how anthropologists actually study sport → to character and virtue. Knowing which move you're in tells you what a question is really asking.

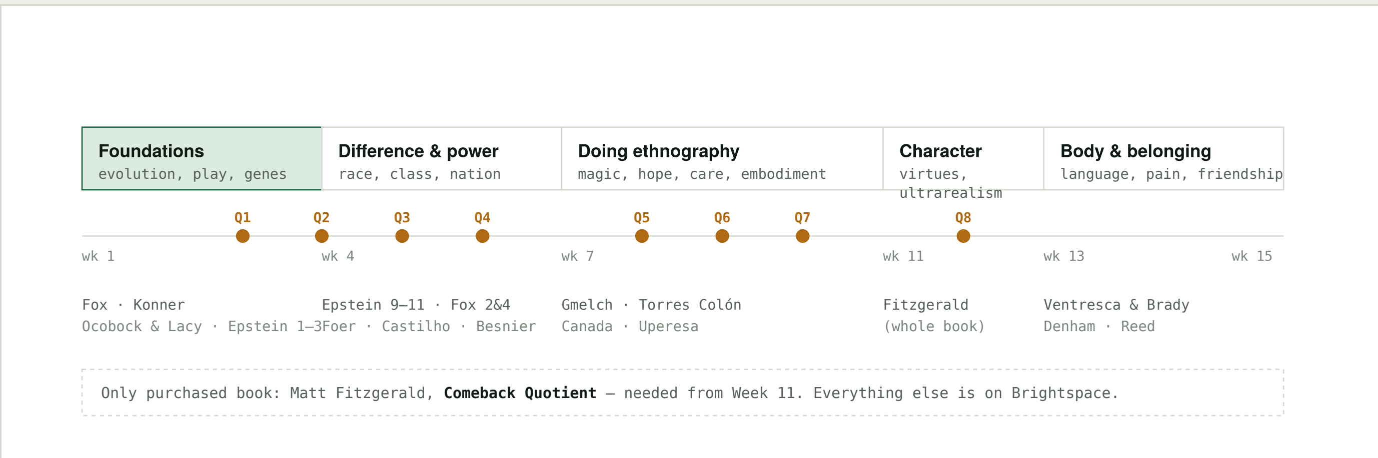

Fig. 1 — Quiz placement is not even. Six of the eight quizzes fall in Weeks 3–10; there is a long quiz-free stretch at the end where reflections carry the weight.

03 The five ideas everything hangs on

If you learn nothing else, learn these. Almost any question in this course can be answered by picking the right one and giving an example.

1. Embodiment

Your body is not just biology — it is biology *shaped by* culture, history, and practice, and experienced from the inside. A jump shot, a limp, a fear of the pool: all embodied.

2. Biocultural

Refuse the nature-*vs*-nurture question. The right question is always: **how** do genes and environment work together here, and **how much** does each contribute?

3. Play → ritual → sport

Sport is not an invention of civilization. It grows out of play, which is older than humans, and it carries ritual meaning — Mayan ball courts were temples.

4. Race is a social fact, not a biological unit

Genetic variation is real; *races* as discrete biological groups are not. Africa holds most human genetic diversity. “Black athletic gene” stories collapse under this.

5. Sport reflects *and* reproduces power

Gender, race, class, and nation are made visible in sport — and made harder to challenge by it. Sport can “enrich or stifle,” “oppress or liberate.”

The two course capacities

(B) Systematic & structural thinking — seeing sport inside larger systems. **(C) Cultural & interpretative investigation** — reading difference as meaning, not fact.

Week 2

Why we play like apes

Readings: Fox, *The Ball*, Prologue & Ch. 1 · Konner, “Play, Social Learning, and Teaching” · lecture slides.

ARGUMENT IN ONE LINE — FOX

Play looks pointless, costs real energy, and can get you killed — which means evolution kept it for a reason: it builds brains, bodies, and the ability to agree on rules.

The paradox that starts the chapter

Play is defined by everyone as useless. Carl Diem: “purposeless activity, for its own sake.” Huizinga: “not serious.” Roger Caillois: “an occasion of pure waste” — then spent 200 pages writing about it. Stuart Brown, of the National Institute for Play, lists **seven characteristics** (this is exam-ready material):

1. **Voluntary** — you're not obliged to do it
2. **Inherent attraction** — it's fun
3. **Freedom from time** — you lose track of it
4. **Diminished consciousness of self**
5. **Improvisation** — make-believe, invention
6. **Continuation desire** — you never want to stop
7. **Apparently purposeless**

Melvin Konner calls play “a central paradox of evolutionary biology.” Here's the paradox drawn out:

COSTS — WHY PLAY SHOULD HAVE DIED OUT

Young mammals burn up to **15% of their calories** playing — calories that could fuel growth.

Peru, 1988: sea lions attacked sea pups. **22 of the 26 pups killed** were playing in tidal pools and never saw the attack coming.

Play exposes animals to injury and predation for no obvious material gain.

PAYOFFS — WHY IT DIDN'T

Rats allowed to play developed higher **BDNF** — a nerve-growth protein — in the amygdala and prefrontal cortex. Isolated rats stayed socially clumsy into adulthood.

Across **15 mammal species**, bigger relative brain size tracked with more play (Pellis).

Athletes crossed a simulated traffic street more successfully — not faster feet, **faster thinking.**

Fig. 2 — Fox's structure of argument. Notice the move: name the cost, then show a measured benefit. Reuse this shape in reflections.

The dolphins (the example most likely to be quizzed)

Fox visits Gulf World Marine Park in Panama City Beach to see psychologist **Stan Kuczaj** and his rough-toothed dolphins. Three things to remember:

- **Balls beat everything.** In a five-year study of 16 captive dolphins, they initiated spontaneous play with balls more than with any other object, with bubbles, or even with each other. Fox's phrase: if play is brain food, ball play is a *protein bar*. Balls are **“kinetically interesting”** — the most animate of inanimate objects — and they are **social tools**.
- **Rules emerge on their own.** In ten minutes, free play with Fox became a competitive interspecies ball game with an unspoken but mutually understood set of rules. That is sport in miniature.
- **“Moderately discrepant events”** (Piaget). Players keep tweaking the rules to make things slightly harder — that's how play sharpens cognition.
- **EQ** (encephalization quotient): humans 7.0, dolphins ~4.5, great apes 1.5–3. More brain, more play.

Konner's play categories (from the slides)

Konner's chapter gives the taxonomy the lecture slides use. Learn the two axes:

BY PLAYERS & OBJECT

Solitary locomotor-rotational
spinning, running, climbing — body alone

Object play
a ball, a stick, a stone — manipulating the world

Social play
chasing, wrestling, pretending — needs a partner

BY CHARACTER

Serious play

Master play

Rough-and-tumble

Adult play

Childhood play rehearses: bodily skill · bio-psychological roles

Fig. 3 — Konner's categories as used in lecture. The slides also frame play as “behavioral fat” — a stored surplus a species can afford, and an evolutionary guard against hardship.

Two more things from Fox worth a quiz point

- **The play deficit.** Children spend **50% less time playing outdoors** than in the 1970s; ages 10–16 average just **12.6 minutes/day** of vigorous activity (NICHD-funded, 2004).
- **The throwing hypothesis** (William Calvin, *The Throwing Madonna*). Accurate one-armed throwing may have driven **lateralization** to the left brain — the same hemisphere that handles the rapid muscle sequencing that language needs. Throwing gave an *immediate* return, unlike fire or tools. Speculative, but you should be able to state it.
- **Hunter-gatherers had leisure.** Richard Lee among the !Kung: women could gather three days' food in one day; Marshall Sahlins said hunters “keep bankers' hours.” So play is *not* an invention of civilization.
- **Play is deep in history.** Aboriginal *marn grook*; Copper Inuit *akraurak* (the aurora borealis is *arsarnerit*, “the football players”); Afghan *buzkashi*; Greek *episkyros* and *ephedrismos*; Roman *harpastum*. **Galen** wrote the first scientific case for ball play — and praised it as a social leveler: “even the poorest man can play ball.”

REFLECTION #1 — “SHOULD PLAY BE MORE SERIOUS?”

The tension the prompt wants: Brown's seventh characteristic says play is *apparently purposeless*, yet everything in Weeks 2–3 shows it does serious developmental work. Making play serious (leagues, clinics, travel teams) can destroy exactly the freedom that made it useful. Use the dolphin backstage game vs. the ticketed show as your image.

Week 3

Whose body was built for this?

Readings: Ocobock & Lacy, “Woman the Hunter: The Physiological Evidence” (Quiz #1) · Epstein, *The Sports Gene*, Ch. 1–3.

ARGUMENT IN ONE LINE — OCOBOCK & LACY

The “Man the Hunter” story survives because science only studied the traits where males have the advantage; measured on endurance, female physiology looks at least as well built for hunting.

The story being argued against

The 1966 symposium and 1968 volume ***Man the Hunter*** (Lee & DeVore) made hunting the engine of human evolution — and gave it to men. Laughlin: “Man's life as a hunter supplied all the other ingredients for achieving civilization.” Zihlman's rebuttal is the line to memorize: these pictures of the past are “**backward projections of modern cultural sex stereotypes**” onto people who lived a million years ago.

Feminist anthropology answered with Slocum's **“Woman the Gatherer”** (1975) and Dahlberg's volume (1981) — but Ocobock & Lacy say that was only half a fix: it still handed hunting to men. Hrdy's *The Woman That Never Evolved* went further.

The data gap (a favorite quiz fact)

- Only **34%** of participants in sport & exercise science research are female.
- Only **14%** in nutritional-supplement research.
- In athletic-performance studies, **3%** of publications are female-only vs. **63%** male-only.

Also required: **there is more variation within sexes than between them**, and every metric overlaps. Sex, like gender, is not a strict binary.

FEMALE-TYPICAL → ENDURANCE

Estrogen (E2) → **70% more fatty-acid oxidation**
Adiponectin up to **65% higher** — spares glycogen
Intramuscular fat: **58 g/kg** vs. 23 g/kg
More Type I (slow, fatigue-resistant) fibers
Wider pelvis → **20–35% better load-carrying economy**
Uses **90%** of stored elastic energy in a jump (men ~50%)

MALE-TYPICAL → POWER

More muscle mass → **40–75% greater strength**
(gap largest in the upper body)
Larger heart, larger lungs, more fat-free mass
More Type IIa fast-oxidative fibers
But: control for size and muscle mass and
the strength difference **disappears.**

MUSCLE FIBRE COMPOSITION, VASTUS LATERALIS (%)

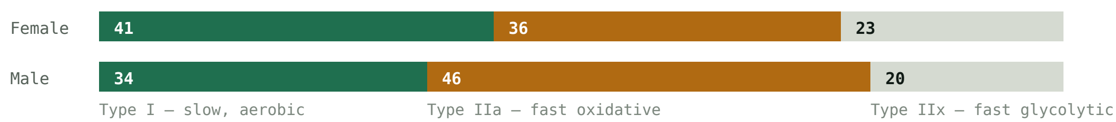

Fig. 4 — Adapted from Ocobock & Lacy, Figures 2 and 3, plus Haizlip et al. fibre data. Every one of these is an **average with heavy overlap**, not a rule about individuals.

The killer evidence

- Women and men perform similarly at **42 km**; women **outperform** men beyond **90 km**. One model predicts female advantage in events **65 km and longer**.
- Persistence hunting involves chases of **17–33 km** — endurance, not speed. Bramble & Lieberman's founding paper on it **never mentions sex**.
- Pacing: in 190,000+ runners at the Bolder Boulder 10K, women were **1.96×** more likely to hold pace at halfway.
- Women show less muscle damage after exercise (attenuated creatine kinase and heat-shock protein responses) → faster recovery.
- **The Agta** of the Philippines: women hunted with dogs and bows into late pregnancy and returned months postpartum. Also Inuit, Tiwi, Ojibwa.
- **Sophie Power** ran the 168 km Ultra-Trail du Mont-Blanc while breastfeeding a three-month-old — the paper's closing image.

The elegant twist: pregnancy and lactation cost ~**500–600 kcal/day extra**. Motherhood *is* a multi-year endurance event — so it may be what *selected for* female endurance, rather than a handicap that ruled women out of hunting.

ARGUMENT IN ONE LINE — EPSTEIN, CH. 1–3

Elite skill is not fast reflexes and it is not 10,000 hours — it is learned pattern-recognition (“software”) running on physical equipment that varies a lot between people (“hardware”).

Ch. 1 — Jennie Finch strikes out the MVPs

Softball pitcher Jennie Finch struck out Albert Pujols, Mike Piazza, Barry Bonds — and Alex Rodriguez refused to bat. **Not because she was faster.** Her 68 mph underhand pitch from 43 feet arrives in roughly the same time as a 95 mph fastball from 60'6".

The numbers that explain it: simple reaction time is ~**200 ms** for everyone — teachers, lawyers, pros alike. A pitch takes **400 ms** to arrive. The contact window is **5 ms**. So a hitter must commit before the ball is halfway. “Keep your eye on the ball” is **literally impossible**. Pujols scored in the **66th percentile** for simple reaction time against college students.

What experts actually have: **chunking** (Chase & Simon, 1973) — grouping information into meaningful patterns. De Groot's chess masters rebuilt real boards from a 3-second glance; on **random** boards their advantage vanished. Janet Starkes' **occlusion tests** showed the same for volleyball and field hockey. Bruce Abernethy: hide a badminton player's forearm and an elite player becomes a near-novice. Facing Finch, Pujols had *no database* — a chess master facing a random board.

Ch. 2 — Two high jumpers

Stefan Holm: 20-year love affair with the high jump, probably more jumps taken than anyone alive, Olympic gold in 2004, and an Achilles so stiff it took **1.8 tons** to stretch it 1 cm (~4× average). **Donald Thomas**: took up high jump on a cafeteria bet, cleared 7'3.25" on the **seventh jump of his life**, and beat Holm at the 2007 World Championships with **eight months** of training — and an unusually long (10¼") Achilles tendon. He has not improved a centimeter since.

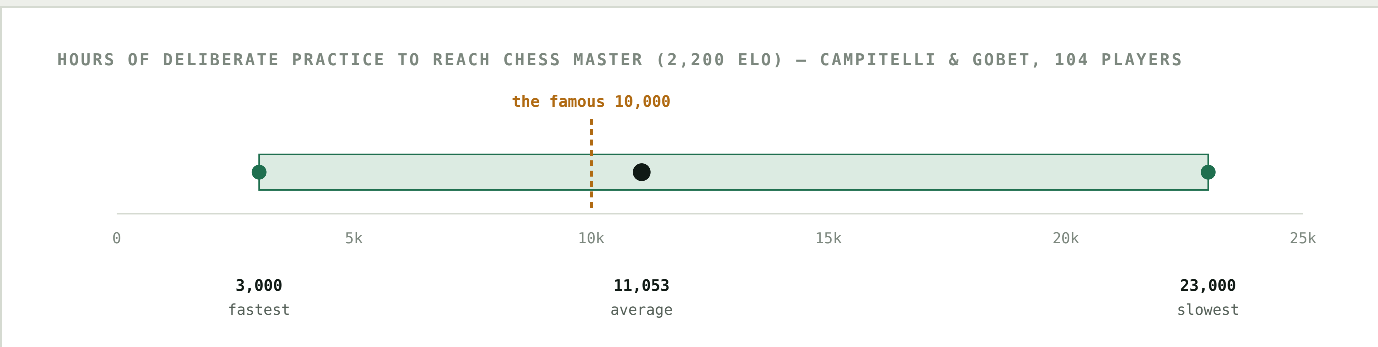

Fig. 5 — The range, not the average, is the finding: some people needed eight times more practice to reach the same level, and several players logged 25,000+ hours without ever making master. Epstein's joke: “the 7,000-to-40,000-hours rule just doesn't have the same ring to it.”

QUIZ TRAP

K. Anders Ericsson **never used the phrase “10,000-hours rule.”** He credits its popularity to a chapter title in Gladwell's *Outliers*, which he says “misconstrued” the violin study. The violin study was **cross-sectional and retrospective** on 10 pre-screened students — not a longitudinal test. Dan McLaughlin's golf project was the attempt at one.

Ch. 3 — The hardware and software paradigm

The chapter's whole point in one figure:

HARDWARE (innate)

Visual acuity — MLB average **20/13**
Depth perception, contrast sensitivity
Achilles length, tendon stiffness
Sprint speed — “you can't teach speed”

→

SOFTWARE (learned)

Chunks & templates from practice
Anticipatory body-cue reading
Automation — skill drops out of the frontal lobe, becomes unconscious

→

RESULT

Better hardware doesn't just raise the ceiling — it makes the software **download faster.**
Neither works alone.

Evidence: German child tennis players — **general athleticism predicted how fast they acquired tennis skill** (Steffi Graf and Boris Becker were in that sample).

Fig. 6 — Epstein's core model. Also from Ch. 3: the Australian Institute of Sport turned surf-lifesaving and water-skiing athletes into Olympic skeleton racers in 14 months — “talent transfer” — and Danish research found late specialization worked *better* in centimeter/gram/second sports.

Week 4 The (un)science of race

Readings: Epstein, *The Sports Gene*, Ch. 9–11 (Quiz #2) · Fox, Ch. 2 & 4.

ARGUMENT IN ONE LINE — EPSTEIN, CH. 9–11

Genetic variation is real and it is mostly *inside* Africa — which is exactly why “Black people are built to sprint” is bad genetics, even though specific traits with specific histories really do cluster in specific populations.

Ch. 9 — We are all Black (sort of)

Yale geneticist **Kenneth Kidd** collected DNA worldwide. Every stretch of the genome he looked at had **more variation in African populations**. On one stretch, a single population of African Pygmies had more variation than the entire rest of the world combined. His line: “from a genetic point of view, all Europeans look alike.”

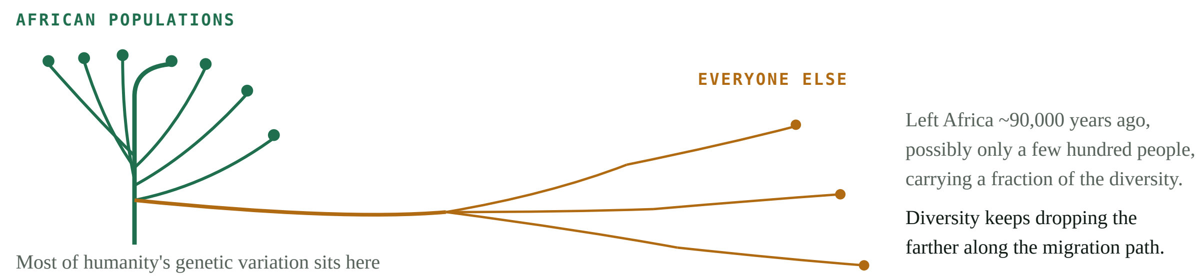

Fig. 7 — The “recent African origin” model. Consequence for sport: Kidd's thought experiment — for any trait with a genetic component, both the *fastest and the slowest* person on earth might be African. Competition only ever looks at one tail.

The nuance you must hold onto

- Humans are **99–99.5% identical** at the DNA level (and 95% similar to chimps) — but at least **15 million letters** differ between individuals. Similar ≠ unimportant.
- Self-identified race matched blind DNA identification in **3,631 of 3,636** Americans — but Kidd & Tishkoff add that with every world population included, the picture becomes a **continuous spectrum**, not discrete groups.
- The proportion of variation *within* vs. *between* groups **depends on the trait**: ~90% of skull-shape variation is within groups; ~90% of skin-color variation is between them.
- African Americans range from **1% to 99% West African ancestry** (Tishkoff).

ACTN3 — the “sprint gene”

Kathryn North was drafting a letter to *Nature Genetics* announcing a new muscular dystrophy gene — then tested the healthy family members and found they had the same variant. The **X variant** stops production of alpha-actinin-3 in fast-twitch fibers; the **R variant** makes it.

- ~25% of East Asians and ~18% of white Australians are **XX**. **Under 1%** of Zulu — and of African populations generally.
- Of 32 Australian sprinters who reached the Olympics, **zero** were XX. No Finnish or Greek Olympic sprinter tested was XX.
- North's own caution: ACTN3 “contributes a little,” there may be hundreds of genes, and diet, environment and opportunity all matter.

THE LINE TO QUOTE

Carl Foster: “**If you want to know if your kid is going to be fast, the best genetic test right now is a stopwatch.**” ACTN3 rules out about 1 billion of 7 billion people — and rules out almost no one of African descent. Commercial genetic testing for athleticism is, in Epstein's word, **nearly worthless**.

Ch. 10 — Two scientists, opposite conclusions

Set up as a debate you should be able to reproduce:

	YANNIS PITSILADIS	ERROL MORRISON & PATRICK COOPER
Claim	Environment & a talent-spotting system	A malaria-driven biological history
Evidence	Every Jamaican child sprints on sports day; “Champs” (since 1910, 100 schools, 35,000-seat stadium); local boosters like Charles Fuller recruiting Sherone Simpson; Bolt and Blake both wanted to play cricket	West African malaria selected for sickle-cell trait and genetically low hemoglobin; a “compensatory mechanism” shifted muscle toward fast-twitch fibers (Bouchard's 1986 Laval study)
Weak spot	Doesn't explain why the finalists are so consistently of West African descent	The final step — hemoglobin → fiber type — has **never been tested in humans**. Only one mouse study and one rat study.

Pitsiladis's data undercut the romantic **“Maroon warrior”** theory: Maroons are not genetically distinguishable from other Jamaicans, and one of his grad students had *more* sprint gene variants than “the likes of a Usain Bolt.” His advice to British runners: “Go into sprinting. Don't worry because you're white.”

Ch. 11 — What is genuinely established

- **Allen's rule** (long limbs) and **Bergmann's rule** (narrow build) at low latitudes — both help running and jumping. Max speed scales with the square root of leg length.
- Sickle-cell trait protects against malaria (Allison, 1954) — a **textbook evolutionary trade-off**.
- Carriers all but disappear from running events over 800 m; they are **overrepresented** in jumps and throws. Since 2000, nine Division I football deaths in training were tied to sickle-cell trait; the NCAA now screens.
- Low hemoglobin also protects against malaria — iron supplementation in malarial Africa **increased** severe malaria, and the WHO backtracked in 2006.

> **COOPER'S MOST IMPORTANT POINT — AND THE ONE FOR REFLECTIONS**
>
> The belief that physical superiority implies intellectual inferiority “**only developed when physical superiority became associated with African Americans**” — around 1936. It was **a result of bigotry, not a cause of it**. Several scientists told Epstein they have relevant data and will never publish it. Cooper's answer: **more careful inquiry, not less**.

04 Terms you should be able to define cold

Objective quiz questions live here.

Embodiment
Biology, culture, and lived experience intertwined in a body.

Biocultural approach
Studying how biology and culture jointly produce a trait or practice.

Chunking
Grouping information into meaningful patterns; the basis of expertise (Chase & Simon).

Occlusion test
Cutting off visual information early to measure anticipation (Starkes, Abernethy).

Deliberate practice
Effortful, cognitively engaged, error-correcting practice — usually solitary.

Matthew effect
The already-better improve faster with the same training (Thorndike).

Talent transfer
Moving a good general athlete into a better-suited sport (Australia's skeleton project).

Persistence hunting
Running prey to exhaustion over 17–33 km; endurance, not speed.

Sexual division of labor
The assignment of tasks by sex — assumed to be deep and biological; Ocobock & Lacy dispute that.

Type I / IIa / IIx fibers
Slow-aerobic / fast-oxidative / fast-glycolytic muscle.

Genotype vs. phenotype
Genetic code vs. its physical expression.

Genetic drift
Change in variant frequency by chance, not selection.

Recent African origin
All non-Africans descend from one small group that left Africa ~90,000 years ago.

Homo ludens
Huizinga's "Man the Player," proposed alongside *Homo sapiens*.

05 Quiz yourself

Answer out loud before you open each one. Ten questions in the style the syllabus describes: main arguments plus the evidence attached to them.

Q **Why couldn't Albert Pujols hit Jennie Finch?**

He had no mental database of her body movements, pitch tendencies, or softball spin — no chunks to read. Since a hitter must commit before the ball is halfway to the plate, he was left reacting, and raw reaction time (his was 66th percentile) isn't enough.

Q **What did the random-chessboard experiment prove?**

That masters' memory advantage is **learned pattern recognition, not superior innate memory**. On arrangements that could never occur in a real game, their recall dropped to average.

Q **State the strongest evidence against a strict 10,000-hours rule.**

Campitelli & Gobet: master level took anywhere from 3,000 to 23,000 hours; some players logged 25,000+ and never made master. And elite athletes in basketball, field hockey and wrestling average closer to 4,000/4,000/6,000 sport-specific hours.

Q **Name three physiological reasons females may be suited to endurance.**

Any three of: 70% greater fatty-acid oxidation; higher adiponectin (up to 65%); more intramuscular fat (58 vs. 23 g/kg); more Type I fibers; better load-carrying economy (20–35%); less exercise-induced muscle damage; more consistent pacing.

Q **What is wrong with *Man the Hunter*, according to Slocum?**

“A theory that leaves out half the human species is unbalanced” — and because the fossil data are so scant, bias fills the gaps with just-so stories.

Q **Why does Kidd say the fastest *and* the slowest human might both be African?**

Because African populations hold the greatest genetic diversity, so for any genetically influenced trait the extremes at both ends should be overrepresented there. Sport only ever measures one end.

Q **What does ACTN3 actually tell you?**

Mostly who *won't* run an Olympic 100 m final — the XX genotype is essentially absent among elite sprinters. It rules out roughly 1 in 7 people worldwide and almost no one of African descent. Foster: use a stopwatch.

Q Give the environmental explanation for Jamaican sprinting.

Every child sprints at school sports day; adult enthusiasts recruit fast kids into track high schools; "Champs" gives them a 35,000-seat proving ground and scholarships; pro clubs like MVP keep them on the island. Talent is *kept in the sprint pipeline* instead of leaking into football or basketball as it does in the US.

Q What makes the Cooper & Morrison malaria hypothesis only a hypothesis?

The malaria → sickle-cell and malaria → low-hemoglobin links are established. The final step — that low hemoglobin drove a shift toward fast-twitch fibers — has been shown only in one mouse and one rat study, and never tested in humans.

Q How does Fox answer his son's question, "why do we play ball?"

Because play is brain food and balls are the richest kind — kinetically interesting, socially binding objects that build motor skill, cognitive flexibility, and the shared rules that make cooperation possible. It's older than civilization, not a product of it.

06 Writing reflections that earn the points

Fourteen of them, self-assessed against a rubric. No AI, in any capacity. The prompts are explicitly about *character*, so the VIA framework is the vocabulary the course wants you to use.

A four-move template

1. **Name the concept** from the reading, precisely, with the author. Not "sports build character" — "Konner's category of social play."
2. **Attach one piece of evidence** from the text (a study, a number, a case).
3. **Bring one thing from your own life or from this week's sports news** — this is why the course requires you to follow current events.
4. **Say what it costs you.** The strongest reflections admit what the idea makes uncomfortable. Then grade yourself honestly against the rubric.

Prompts already scheduled

#1 Should play be more serious? · #2 Are elite athletes super-humans? · #3 How do sports reflect cultural norms? · #4 Sports and the virtue of transcendence · #5 Responsibility for structural inequality · #7 What is caring? · #9 Care, accepting, embracing · #10 Addressing reality · #11 Inspiration · #12 Perspective, kindness, fairness · #13 Humility in sports talk · **Final: Ultrarealism and human flourishment.**

The VIA 24 character strengths, grouped by virtue

WISDOM	COURAGE	HUMANITY	JUSTICE
Creativity Curiosity Judgment Love of learning Perspective	Bravery Perseverance Honesty Zest	Love Kindness Social intelligence	Teamwork Fairness Leadership
TEMPERANCE	**TRANSCENDENCE**		
Forgiveness Humility Prudence Self-regulation	Appreciation of beauty Gratitude Hope Humor Spirituality		

Reflection #4 asks specifically about **transcendence** — in VIA terms that's appreciation of beauty & excellence, gratitude, hope, humor, and spirituality: the strengths that connect a person to something larger. That is exactly what a stadium, a national team, or a ritual ball court does.

Built from the Fall 2026 syllabus and the Weeks 1–4 Brightspace readings: Fox, *The Ball* (Prologue, Ch. 1) · the "We Play Like Apes" lecture slides · Ocobock & Lacy, *American Anthropologist* 126:7–18 · Epstein, *The Sports Gene*, Ch. 1–3 and 9–11 · VIA Institute on Character.

Konner's chapter had no readable text layer in the project file — those notes follow the lecture slides. Update this page once you have the PDF text.

Not a substitute for doing the reading, and not usable for reflections — the syllabus forbids AI there.